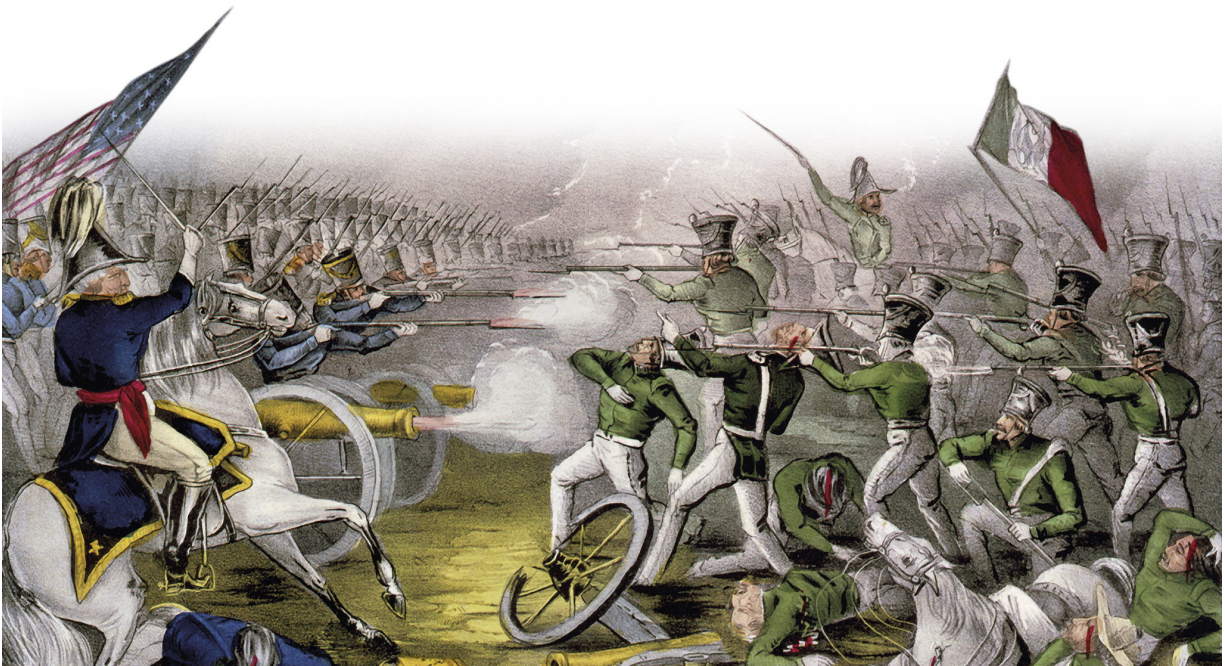


annexation, and hostilities began when American dragoons engaged Mexican cavalry along the disputed Rio Grande border. On May 10, 1846, President James K. Polk declared, “American blood has been shed on American soil.” Despite the opposition of influential figures such as New York *Tribune* editor Horace Greeley, Congress declared war three days later.

In September, an army under General Zachary Taylor captured the Mexican city of Monterey. Santa Anna, whose career had taken several twists since his capture in 1836, returned to Mexico from exile and declared himself president once more. In February 1847, Taylor defeated him at the Battle of Buena Vista. In March, General Winfield Scott launched the largest amphibious landing ever, when his 12,000 troops disembarked near Veracruz. Scott’s army finally entered Mexico City on September 14.



The Battle of Buena Vista

At Buena Vista in February 1847, General Zachary Taylor used his artillery to such good effect that he defeated a larger force under the Mexican leader, Santa Anna. The victory helped propel him into the presidency in 1849.